

“intelligence tests.” (These tests can be summarized quickly, represented by a few clever riddles, or turned into a long comedy sequence, as you desire.)

When the *berbalang* has learned all it can from the characters, it suggests they might like to rest and offers them a room in area 6.11 or area 6.25. If they ask to talk to someone in charge, it offers to introduce them to Vargo, the lord of the cube. If the characters seem like they might cause trouble, the *berbalang* tells them that Vargo can teleport them back to their homes—and sets up a masterful plan of deceit. See area 6.25 for more information.

If the characters attack the *berbalang*, it fights back but flees as quickly as it can to alert Vargo. If Bunch ever faces the characters again, it uses its Spectral Duplicate feature to hide in a safe place while the duplicate fights.

AREA 6.14: SOUL TAP

As the characters approach this room, they hear a sudden scream that quickly fades away. If they wait in the hall, the pattern of sound repeats every six seconds.

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. Some great disaster has torn this chamber apart. Everything that remains has a crudely blocky appearance, as if shaped of thousands of black metal cubes. Huge rends in the metal walls expose massive steel girders and pipes whose blocky lengths are bent and twisted. Red steam spills out of the pipes, and red glowing bricks in the walls blink and flash erratically. The floor, once covered in square white tiles, is split open to an enormous hole opening up to darkness far below, and edged with blocky, twisted girders and pipes. Multicolored squares of tile cover the ceiling.

Unpixelated. The room looks much the same, though the twisted girders and pipes are revealed to be viciously jagged. The remnants of great machines stand along the edges of the room, likewise smashed beyond recognition. The tiles in the ceiling are a mosaic incorporating symbols of order, reincarnation, and rebirth. With a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Arcana or Religion) check, a character recognizes ceremonial designs showing the Great Wheel that represents the position of the planes. Characters who can read Infernal or Primordial note sigils praising cosmic law and justice, and talking of how order must be obeyed even when it seems cruel or arbitrary.

Long Way Down. When the characters first enter this area, a pulse of light appears in the center of the room, directly below the Great Wheel image in the ceiling. Within the light, a naked humanoid appears in midair, then immediately screams as they plummet down the hole in the floor and vanish into darkness. A character near the edge who listens with a successful DC 15 Wisdom (Perception) check hears the scream abruptly stop and a crunching sound from below.

Every six seconds, this spectacle repeats itself, with another figure appearing in the air and falling to their death. All are naked adults but vary in gender, race, and culture, including humans, gnomes, dwarves, the occasional goblinoid, and pale dwarves the characters

might recognize as *duergar*. All are doomed to die as they fall some 400 feet to area 6.39.

Interrupted Fall. The characters might attempt to rescue one or more of the falling individuals, using spells such as *feather fall* or *telekinesis*. Creatures saved from their fate are confused and have no idea where they are. All are lawful evil (or occasionally lawful neutral) individuals who died and have been reborn in new bodies resembling the ones they used to have. They know nothing about Acheron except what they might have heard in legends, and might be surprised to be told they’ve ended up there. Each creature has **veteran** statistics, adjusted for the lack of weapons and armor.

If the characters figure out a way to rescue large numbers of reborn souls (for example, by creating a solid structure to bridge the open center of the room), they discover to their peril that these humanoids all transform to pixelated **veterans** within 1 hour of wandering around the cube. If you don’t want to deal with the complication of hundreds of new guards joining the ranks of the skull lord’s servants, you might decide that the soul tap’s corrupted magic causes some or all of them to drop dead or vanish a few minutes after they appear.

Souls on Tap. A *detect magic* spell identifies powerful divine magic and transmutation in this area, centered in the pulsing light where the bodies appear. This room was the second most important site in Cube 1717 after the engine room: the place where the souls of lawful evil dead were reborn to be assigned new duties in area 6.13. When the *yugoloths* invaded the cube, they destroyed this area to shut off the flow of souls. But when the Six-Face Throne was activated, so was the soul tap. Only destroying the Heart Engine (see area 6.28) or a *wish* spell can turn it off now.

Characters who observe the damaged floor and walls see that they are slowly rebuilding themselves. If the characters are unable to destroy the Heart Engine before the floor of the room grows back in one week, it will once again provide the skull lord with an endless stream of new recruits.

Climbing the Girders. Descending the mangled girders and pipes is difficult and dangerous. Climbing the 200 feet between this area and area 6.32 requires four successful DC 17 Strength (Athletics) checks (one for every 50 feet climbed). On a failed check, a character slips and falls, plummeting up to 400 feet to area 6.39 and taking 20d6 bludgeoning damage. A character who sees the area as pixelated has disadvantage on the check.

With each successful check, a character still takes 7 (2d6) slashing damage from the jagged metal along the descent path.

AREA 6.15: LADDER SHAFT

A 20-foot-wide shaft with ladders on all four sides runs some 200 feet between the upper and middle levels beneath face 6. When Cube 1717 was fully functional, magic in the shaft allowed freight and important individuals to levitate up and down, but that magic has failed.

AREA 6.16: ACHERON'S ARMORY

The features of this area appear different depending on whether the characters have an unpixelated view.

Pixelated. This cavernous room is hotter than the corridors outside. Cubic steel terraces are stacked with blocky caricatures of weapons, while gleaming shields and armor are set on racks across the floor, all appearing as though forged of jagged cubes. The heat in the chamber comes from large furnaces venting pixelated smoke and flame. Blue and white glowing bricks in the walls and ceiling illuminate the room. Several small pixelated creatures wander near the furnaces.

Unpixelated. These chambers contain weapons and armor of all descriptions—enough to outfit an army, and all forged by duergar smiths or shaped by gnome crafters. Anvils, tongs, hammers, and other tools lie scattered about.

Fiery Exits. Numerous pipes extend from the furnaces to disappear into the walls where they lead to other areas. These pipes range from 2 feet to 5 feet across, with the largest pipes connecting to the Heart Engine at area 6.28. At your discretion, creatures with immunity to fire damage might be able to creep through the pipes into other areas.

Arms and Armor. The characters can claim any kind of nonmagical medium or heavy armor they want from this area (including hide armor made from the skin of Acheronian beasts), as well as nonmagical weapons of any type. Characters who spend some time searching the farthest corners of the chamber also find multiple examples of siege equipment (see chapter 8 of the *Dungeon Master's Guide*; size Huge or smaller only).

Clockworks. The gnomish clockworks that infest face 2 were made here by the mad derro architect Avnas

and her pupils. Several of those constructs still crawl and rattle along near the forges: three **oaken bolters**^M, ten **bronze scouts**^M, and four **iron cobras**^M, all pixelated.

The iron cobras and oaken bolters attack nonpixelated creatures on sight unless commanded not to by an intelligent pixelated creature. Unless they are attacked, the bronze scouts crawl within 5 feet of intruders, harmlessly sniff them, then wander off.

If the characters destroy all the clockworks here and return to the room later, another 1d6 + 1 pixelated **bronze scouts**^M will have crawled out from hiding to behave as noted above.

Any noise of battle in this room is audible to creatures in area 6.19 or area 6.28.

AREA 6.17: AVNAS'S LAIR

If they have not been encountered and killed already, there is a 50 percent chance that Avnas and her gray

render pet are in this area when the characters come here. They are otherwise wandering elsewhere in the cube, including on the surface (see "Random Surface Encounters").

The door to this area from area 6.16 is blocked by a heap of black, blue, and gray metallic cubes that make it appear as though the walls have collapsed. However, any character who inspects these cubes sees that they are not made of metal as they appear to be, but are simply heavy paper covered with metallic paint.

Moving the cubes reveals a 5-foot-wide circular iron hatch that resembles a smaller, handmade version of the huge doors on the cube's exterior. The door is unpixelated and has an unpixelated handprint lock at its center. Both the hatch and the lock are painted with wild arabesque designs and symbols of chaos.

Unlike the regular doors that open to the handprint of a lawful creature, this hatch opens only if the handprint of a chaotic creature (living or dead) is pressed into the lock. Alternatively, characters can batter their way through the hatch, which has AC 17, 30 hit points, and immunity to psychic and poison damage. However, doing so alerts Avnas and the gray render if they are here.

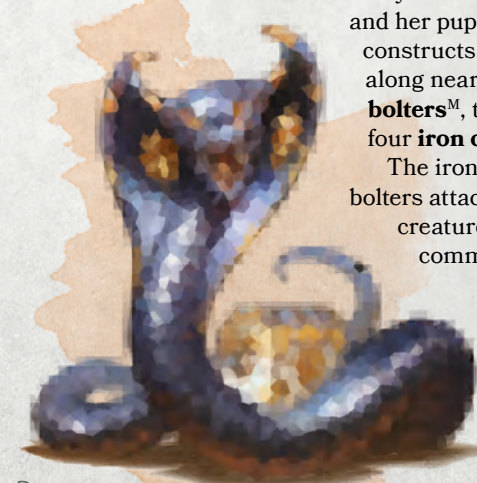
Beyond the door stands a comfortable, cluttered lair and workspace. Unlike the geometric corridors outside, the surfaces of this room are twisted into fabulous curves, ripples, and whorls. This area remains unpixelated as a result of the chaotic energy focused in Avnas's work. It is set with a four-poster bed whose soft mattress is stuffed with plump bat wings, a drafting table, numerous torture devices, comfortable armchairs and divans, a mirror, and a kitchen area where Avnas prepares and cooks homemade sausage. A pile of human, gnome, and duergar bones are the remains of the gray render's food. Several blobby cubical objects set around the place are the pixelated heads of dead enemies, which Avnas talks to as if they were alive.

Avnas and Moxon. This area is home to Avnas, the **derro savant**^M who designed Cube 1717. She has the appearance of a scrawny, deformed dwarf of indeterminate age, with huge white eyes and a tangle of gray hair. On a chain around her neck, she wears the pixelated severed hand of a lawful hobgoblin, used to open the cube's doors. Avnas also carries a +1 *quarterstaff*, as well as numerous bags and pouches containing tinker's tools, jeweler's tools, mason's tools, smith's tools, polyhedral dice, and 850 gp worth of small gems. The derro is infected with the pixelating curse, picked up on one of her many trips outside this area. But she is just beginning to pixelate, with cubic growths visible on her hands and chin.

Avnas is accompanied everywhere by her huge, vicious pet Moxon—a **gray render**^M that serves her



PIXELATED OAKEN BOLTER



PIXELATED
IRON COBRA

faithfully and attacks anyone who threatens her. Moxon is fully pixelated.

Works of Madness. Formerly one of the few chaotic creatures in Acheron, Avnas's mechanical engineering skills quickly made her a prized servant of Earl Andromalius, who coveted her clockworks and machines. Earl Andromalius gifted the derro with a dread magic item called the *book of patterns* (see the "New Magic Items" appendix). The evil dreams bestowed upon the derro by that tome inspired the experiments that turned the quadrone into the Archquadrone and started the pixelating curse.

With the progression of the curse slowed in Avnas because of her chaotic nature, she survived the cataclysm that followed. By the time she emerged from her hiding place, Vargo had created the Six-Face Throne and taken control of the cube. Pledging allegiance at sword point to the skull lord, Avnas is nominally an ally of the "new earl." But she mostly wanders the cube in a state of awe, fascinated by the pixelating curse and the bodies, arms, and armor she has to experiment with.

Avnas is dangerously insane and constantly switches personality traits. Every time the characters meet her, roll a d6 and consult the following table to see how she acts.

d6 Avnas's Personality

- 1 The derro is completely obsessed with some piece of weapon, armor, or machinery. She ignores the characters, muttering to herself. If the characters persistently bother her, Moxon attacks them.
- 2 Avnas is homicidal and paranoid. Seeing the characters as her prey, she stalks and attacks them.
- 3 Convinced that the characters are undead slaves of the skull lord, Avnas rudely commands them to help her dig through bodies or perform some other menial task.
- 4 Avnas is mostly lucid, seeing the characters as threats but curious about how things have changed on the Material Plane since she came to Acheron. She asks about obscure figures of derro culture from thousands of years before. If the characters change the topic, she tries to misdirect them into the clutches of nearby pixelated guards, the balhannoth, or another enemy.
- 5 The derro scratches at the cubes on her face and hands, desperate as she asks the characters for help getting them off. If the characters cure her of the pixelating curse, roll a d6 again to determine her reaction. Thereafter, reroll this result if Avnas is free of the curse.
- 6 Avnas is unfailingly polite and enthusiastic. She answers any questions about Cube 1717 while eagerly engaging the characters in conversation about the wonders of the pixelating curse. (This personality results from the pixelating curse beginning to affect her brain. Reroll this result if Avnas is free of the curse.)

Along with the skull lord, Avnas is one of the only creatures in Cube 1717 who knows the whole story of what brought the cube to the material plane. However,

even she doesn't understand exactly how the dreams sent to her by the *book of patterns* transformed the quadrone and created the pixelating curse. She sees everything as an exciting new experiment, from torture to death to becoming a pixelated creature. Her sociopathic narcissism and self-destructive tendencies make it impossible for the derro to become a true ally of the characters, no matter what they might offer her.

Drafting Table. This metal table and the shelves around it are covered with rulers, styluses, and drafting equipment. A **stone defender**^M stands near the table, inscribed with notes and sketches in Abyssal. Avnas uses the construct as a bulletin board, and it is programmed to attack anyone who goes near the drafting table. If Avnas is in the room, she can command the stone defender to attack intruders.

Canvas scrolls spread across the table show Avnas's architectural plans for the fortresses and barracks she was commissioned to make, as well as her dream projects—insane buildings combining the shapes of flowers, intestines, and seashells.

With a search of this area and a successful DC 15 Intelligence (Investigation) check, a character recognizes Avnas's plans for a huge cubic fortress as depicting the very fortress they are in. The plans show the overall layout of the fortress's faces (including the doors on each face, but not the threats currently found there). It shows all the rooms beneath each face, although not the names or contents of those rooms.

Avnas's Dice Collection. A set of shelves and a table in one corner of the room contain Avnas's treasures—shining, glowing polyhedral objects of all colors, shapes, and sizes, each with its faces marked by numeric symbols. Some are made of stone, others of metal or jewels. Some are sculpted of layered lizard skin. Some are ochre jellies magically kept at a low temperature to keep them solid. On the table stand dice towers, scales, and spiraling glass tubes used to test dice. The floor around the table is scrawled with invocations praising Demogorgon, Juiblex, and the other demon lords.

Avnas's collection of dice weighs 200 pounds in total. Most are merely curiosities, but any character who spends 30 minutes to sort through the collection identifies 50 pounds of valuable dice worth a total of 12,000 gp. The largest of these is a d12 carved from a petrified roc's egg.

Additionally, five unique dice are hidden among the rest:

Eye Die: When this translucent d4 is rolled as an action, the creature rolling it must succeed on a DC 14 Constitution save or have their face transform as their number of eyes changes to the number rolled on the die. A *remove curse* spell restores the creature's normal number of eyes, or they can reroll until they get the desired number. Additional eyes grant a creature no benefit.

Skull Die: This d6 is carved of demon bone and has a skull in place of the 1. When it is rolled as an action, a number of creatures within 60 feet (as determined by the roll) must each succeed on a DC 14 Constitution saving throw or take 35 (10d6) necrotic damage.